

HORS D'OEUVRES | DILIP BOBB

Digital Evolution

I'm no great fan of social networking sites. I believe they tend to promote narcissism, lead to shorter attention spans and are mostly used during office hours. I'm a long way from being a convert but of late, I have mellowed my views, especially after reading about the damage done by Air India staff to music maestro Amjad Ali Khan's favourite sarod. He should have taken a leaf from another musician, American Dave Carroll, who faced a similar situation when United Airlines damaged his treasured Taylor guitar during a flight. Carroll spent nine months trying to get United to pay for damages. During his final exchange with the airline's customer relations manager, Carroll told him that he was left with no choice other than to create a music video for Youtube exposing their lack of cooperation. The manager responded: "Good luck with that one, pal."

The rest is network history. Carroll wrote a song about his experience and posted the video on Youtube. It received over seven million hits. United Airlines took a PR pounding and tried for a settlement in exchange for pulling the video. His response was, "Good luck with that one, pal." Taylor Guitars sent the musician two new guitars in appreciation for the product recognition that led to a sharp increase in orders. That's not just an amazing story but shows the power of social networking sites to bring about positive change and redressal from wrong. Social networking as a powerful consumerist movement is an intriguing thought. It's not just confined to consumerism. During the recent tragedy in Haiti, hundreds of aid workers have turned to Twitter and Facebook to get in touch with one another and better coordinate their relief efforts. It's also allowed families separated by the disaster to reunite.

Social networks, by their enormous reach, have this power to impact society positively

and negatively. The underwear bomber from Yemen was brainwashed by a radical Islamic preacher's videos on his website. Yet, that same global reach offers an ideal platform to do good for society. Businesses can use social networks to communicate on a much larger scale but also gets them to react to customer demands more quickly, a lesson United Airlines did not learn to its cost. A recent book, *Connected: The Surprising Power of Our Social Networks and How They Shape our Lives* concludes that social networks are taking us somewhere exciting, but we have to work out how we deal with the fading boundaries these tools have left in their wake and that means rewriting existing social rules as we go along. It's worth the effort.

SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com



SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Kannada actor **K.S. Ashwath**, 85. He debuted with *Sthree Rathna* and went on to act in over 300 films during his 50-year career.



SELECTED: Cinematographer **V.K. Murthy** for the Dada Saheb Phalke award. He shot films like *Pakeezah* and *Chaudvi ka Chand*. This is the first time that a cinematographer will get the award.

APPOINTED: **K.S. Money** as the secretary-general of the National Human Rights Commission. He is a 1976-batch IAS officer of the Rajasthan cadre.

APPOINTED: **Letika Saran** as the first woman director-general of police of Tamil Nadu. She will be the second woman to head a state police force after Kanchan Chaudhry Bhattacharya in Uttarakhand.



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